

Investigations Division

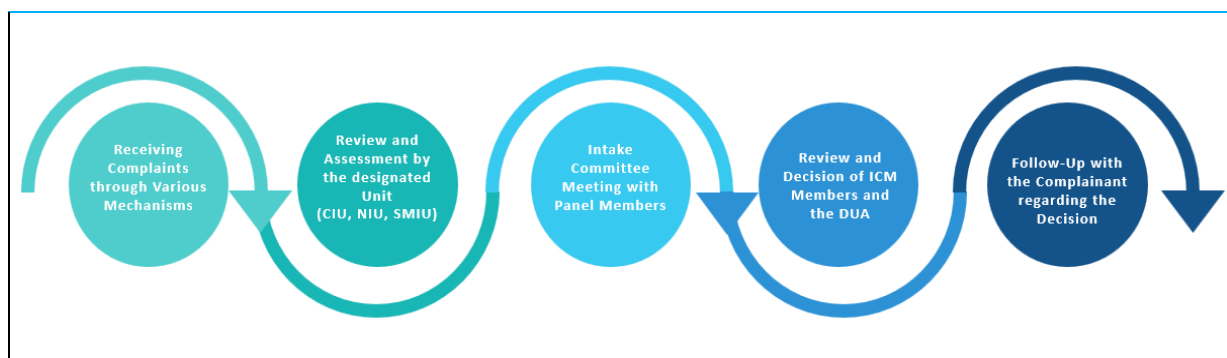
Overview

In 2024, the Investigations Division (ID) of the Department of Internal Oversight Services (DIOS) continued its effort to strengthen UNRWA's adherence to the principle of neutrality by enhancing the operational capacity and responsiveness of the Neutrality Investigations Unit (NIU), which was established in 2023. These actions were aligned with the findings and recommendations of the 2024 Colonna Report and formed part of a broader strategy to reinforce

neutrality safeguards across the Agency, ensuring that UNRWA remains a trusted and impartial actor within a complex and politically sensitive operational context.

In parallel, DIOS/ID developed a roadmap to centralize the Agency's complaint intake mechanisms, which was originally spread across the various UNRWA Field Offices, with the aim of streamlining and unifying efficiency in the handling of allegations and promoting consistency, quality and transparency across the Agency's investigative functions.

Figure 16. The process of Dealing with Complaints



In 2024, the EU Project provided funding to strengthen DIOS ID's capacity to address misconduct, including neutrality breaches. The funding of 5 million Euros was allocated to both DIOS ID and the Ethics Office for this purpose. This funding enabled the Division to complete its post-recruitment phase, boosting its ability to conduct neutrality-related investigations.

Investigations Division Resources

In 2024, a substantial portion of DIOS ID resources were invested in the recruitment of **ten new staff** members, both at General Services and Professional level. The process involved extensive testing, evaluation, interviews, and multiple recruitment cycles. As of December 31, 2024, DIOS ID was able to fill all 16 out of 17 positions of the Division.

Six of the General Services staff were recruited from EU Project Funds. The Professional Staff component includes six staff members, including the Chief Investigations Division, Senior Field Investigations Support Officer, two Senior Investigators, one Intake Investigator, and one Investigations Officer. In addition, two EU project-funded staff members complement the Professional Staff component: a Quality and Assurance Officer and one Investigator.

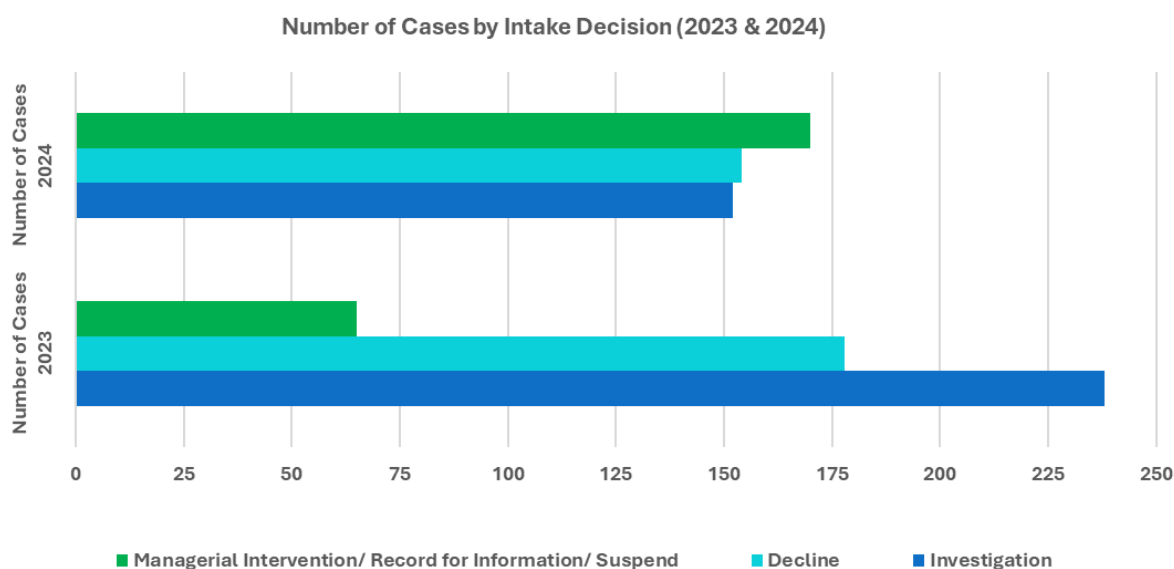
Agency-wide Investigation activities

In 2024, DIOS ID assessed 515 complaints related to both fields and HQ. These complaints contained 595

allegations of misconduct. Out of the 515 complaints assessed by the intake committee, 35% were assessed as warranting further investigation, representing a decrease from 47% in 2023.

This initial assessment represents the committee's evaluation based on the available information at intake. It is noted that the final authority to initiate an investigation lies with the directors. This reduction reflects the **enhanced triage system**, which redirected performance-related complaints to managerial oversight, allowing investigators to focus on reported cases of misconduct that are of high priority.

Figure 17. Number of Agency wide cases by intake decision (2023-2024).



In 2024, the Director of DIOS along with the other field directors approved 31% of cases for investigation compared to 45% in 2023. Additionally, 31% of complaints were declined as they were deemed to lack any corroborating evidence, a slight decrease from 34% in 2023—due

to a more strategic resource allocation approach. Meanwhile, 34% of complaints were recorded for reference, referred to managerial intervention, or suspended pending further evidence.

Analysis of Investigation Cases in 2024

The table below provides a detailed breakdown of cases handled in 2024, covering cases carried forward

from previous years, and cases opened for investigation in 2024, as well as cases closed in 2024.

Figure 18. Agency-wide (UNRWA) Cases in 2024 (includes cash handled by DIOS ID and Field Offices).²

UNRWA	Total cases	Total Number of Allegations	Sexual Exploitation and Abuse	Sexual Harassment	Corporal Punishment	Breach of Neutrality	Assault (Not CP)	Retaliation	Harassment/Discrimination/Abuse of Power	Recruitment Irregularity	Fraud, Theft & Loss to the agency	Other Cases
Open Cases (previous)	302	395	2	2	68	42	13	3	72	11	49	133
Cases Opened	152	183	6	1	37	22	7	1	18	2	42	47
Cases closed	266	342	4	3	55	49	11	3	50	7	50	110
Currently open	188	208	5	1	41	10	8	1	36	5	39	62

In 2024, 302 cases were carried forward from previous years and 152 cases warranted investigation in 2024.

- Fraud, theft and loss to Agency cases were the highest cases to be opened (42) in 2024 of which GFO had 13 cases opened this year, due to ongoing conflict in Gaza.
- Corporal punishment had a slight reduction from last year, but the number of currently opened cases was the highest compared to other types of misconduct. The slight reduction was due to the DLA pilot project, which uses managerial intervention to address part of corporal punishment allegations within LFO.
- Breach of neutrality cases experienced a significant decrease from 2023, due to the

majority of allegations being reported in 2023, following the onset of the conflict in Gaza.

- Harassment, discrimination, and abuse of authority cases had a notable decline. The reduction is due to DIOS's support in helping field offices accurately categorize complaints during IC meetings.
- Assault (Not CP) cases showed a decrease in 2024, influenced by remote work policies in WBFO, GFO, and LFO.

By the end of 2024, 188 cases remained open (compared to 302 as at the end of 2023), reflecting the persistent efforts to resolve issues. The structured triaging and categorization process has helped prioritize high-impact cases, while

² The "Total" column of allegation types represents investigations, not individual cases. Some investigations may involve multiple allegations.

managerial interventions addressed complaints that presented a lower level of risk

Mega Trend analysis of UNRWA cases

The following chart depicts case trends encompassing the years 2021 to 2024. While the number of cases opened for investigation steadily increased each year up until 2023, as there was an apparent decrease in 2024.

This decrease was mainly because of the CIU’s thorough assessment process, which led to more targeted decisions on which cases to investigate, on top of the enhanced resource allocation under DIOS’s Investigations Division.

In 2024, DIOS ID made noteworthy progress in closing cases under investigation, specifically aged cases from previous years, which resulted in a slight increase in the average time to finalize investigations.

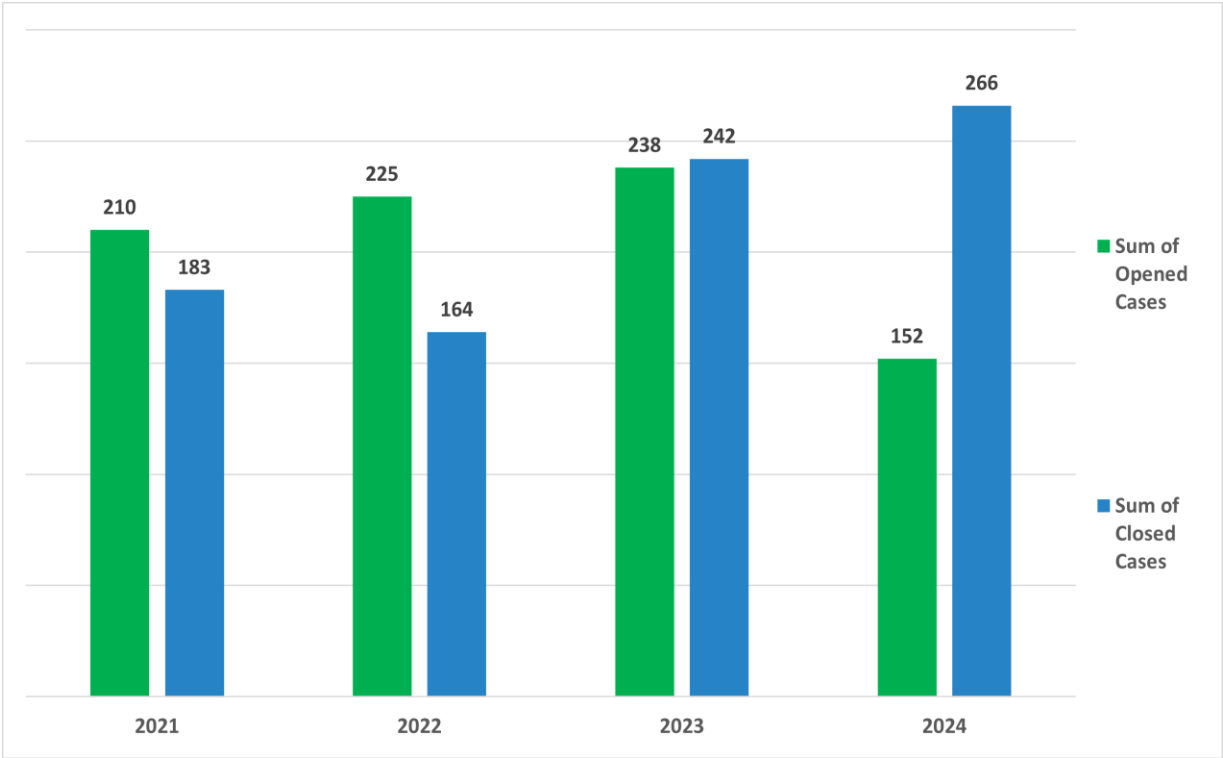


Figure 19. A Column and line chart showing the trend of Opened, Closed and cases carried forward from previous years from 2021 to 2024

Due to the ongoing conflict in Gaza, GFO struggled to close cases, due to difficulties reaching complainants and unreliable communication. Despite these challenges, DIOS ID continued to support these offices, assisting with assessments and helping prepare and finalize closure reports.

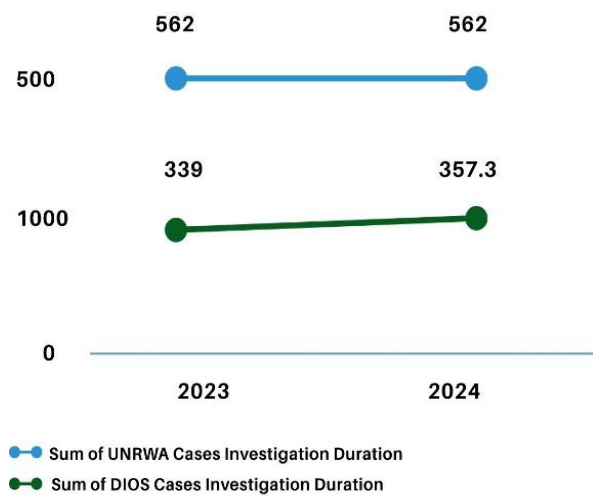
Meanwhile, the increasing trend in neutrality and sexual misconduct allegations led DIOS ID to fully centralize these types of investigations, improving its ability to address these allegations more effectively and efficiently.

Performance Indicators

In 2024, DIOS ID prioritized clearing a backlog of investigations, including cases dating back to 2019, managing to close double the number of cases in 2023. This effort slightly increased investigation timelines but still managed to achieve **81% of the 290-day target**.

As for UNRWA’s investigation duration timeline, the overall case completion time remained steady at 562 days, mostly due to resolving long-pending cases from closing 75 cases dating back to 2022. Despite the delays in timelines, these efforts managed to significantly reduce the backlog. Most cases from 2023 were resolved. This would result in a situation where the backlog will be further decreased moving forward

Figure 20. A Line Chart Showing the Difference between Performance Indicators in 2023 and 2024 in days.

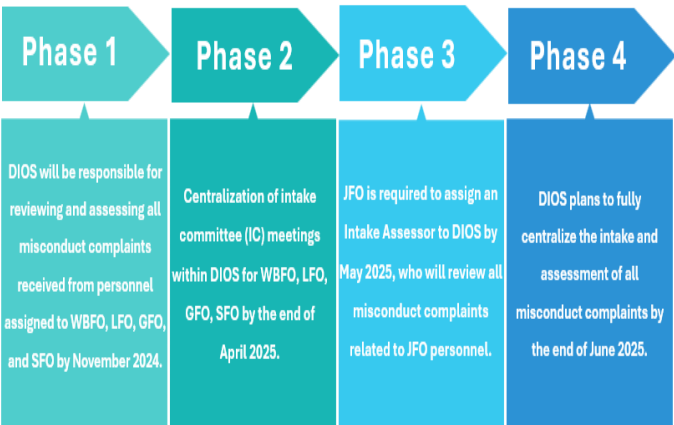


Roadmap Towards the Centralization of Agency-Wide Complaint Intake Practices

The roadmap emerged as a way to address the current decentralized approach in the Field Offices which causes inefficiencies and delays. Hence, centralizing the complaint intake process in 2024, marked a noticeable improvement in managing the intake of complaints.

The roadmap, finalized in January 2025, aimed at the centralization of Agency-wide complaint intake practices and is being rolled out in four phases.

Figure 21. Phases of the Centralization Roadmap



The Work of the Investigations Division Units

Central Intake Unit (CIU)

The DIOS ID managed to increase its capacity when it comes to managing complaints received across the Agency. In 2024, the Central Intake Unit (CIU) received 993 complaints through the three DIOS hotline mechanisms, an increase of 89% from last year (2023: 525).

Out of the 993 complaints received, a total of 515 complaints were assessed and presented at the

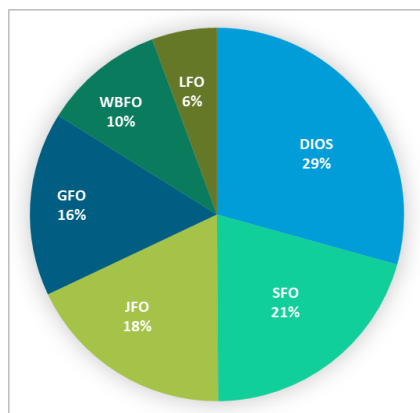
Intake Committee Meetings (IC). The remaining 478 complaints did not involve any potential misconduct or were related to performance issues or were appropriately redirected to the relevant channels.

The 515 misconduct complaints were formally reviewed and presented in IC meetings, with DIOS ID directly handling 151 cases and the Field Offices handling the remaining 364.

Out of the 151 cases, 48 related to breach of neutrality allegations and 40 potential cases of sexual misconduct.

Moreover, DIOS ID had 48 centralized IC meetings and facilitated 65 decentralized IC meetings across the five field offices as follows, JFO 17, SFO 14, GFO 14, WBFO 11 and LFO 9, where complaints were presented as reflected in the accompanying pie chart.

Figure 22. Complaints assessed by DIOS HQ and Field Offices



This occurred following the 2024 centralization of the intake process, as the CIU now handles most of the complaint-intake process, although this process is accompanied by several challenges, including:

- Limited resources hinder the proper handling of non-misconduct complaints.

- The workload causes a challenge in closing the gap between received and resolved complaints.
- The absence of continued cooperation from complainants who have made allegations.

Moving forward, the CIU is shaping its work, increasing the workload capacity, and moving towards the finalization of the centralized intake process.

Neutrality Investigations Unit (NIU)

Despite operating with only two personnel on temporary project-funded contracts for most of 2024, the Neutrality Investigations Unit (NIU) undertook all necessary measures to ensure that the Agency addressed neutrality breach allegations and investigations with greater efficiency and timeliness.

Additionally, in May 2024, the NIU established a roadmap for centralizing the investigation of neutrality-related allegations within DIOS, rather than across the Agency's five Field Investigations Offices. This centralization enabled the implementation of consistent investigative practices Agency-wide, ensuring greater efficiency in the investigation of neutrality breach allegations.

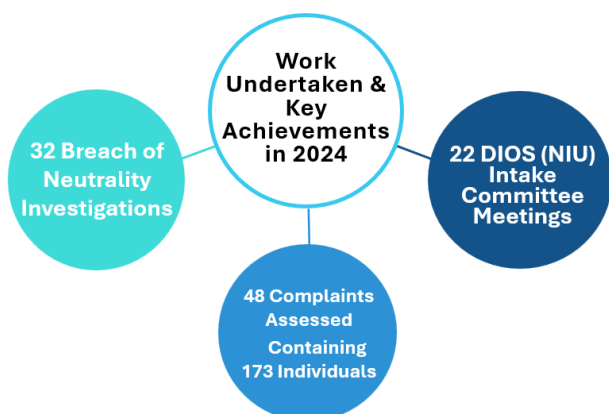
The NIU reviews all neutrality breaches received Agency-wide, ranging from minor infractions to severe ones like involvement in military and political groups. After review, NIU prepares a formal intake assessment and presents it to a DIOS ID-focused committee for deliberation on neutrality breach allegations.

Figure 23. The process of reviewing neutrality allegations.



The diagram below provides an overview of the work and achievements of the NIU in 2024. It highlights the work areas of the NIU, regarding neutrality related cases, the role of NIU intake committee meetings in reviewing complaints, to the overall number of reported cases. In 2024, the newly created Neutrality Investigations Unit received 173 allegations from 48 complaints and managed to produce 32 investigation reports.

Figure 24. The work of NIU and key achievements



Colonna Report and implications for Neutrality

The Colonna report acknowledged that DIOS ID has effective procedures to address neutrality breaches and highlighted its efforts to strengthen investigations, enhance interdepartmental

collaboration, secure resources, and expand neutrality training.

The Colonna report provided 50 recommendations to enhance UNRWA's commitment to neutrality, with five related to DIOS ID. In response, UNRWA launched a High-Level Action Plan on May 13, 2024.

DIOS ID has since begun implementing key measures, including recruiting oversight staff, centralizing investigations for greater efficiency as well as transparency and quality, and increasing resources for neutrality training and standards enforcement.

Sexual Misconduct Investigations Unit

The Sexual Misconduct Investigations Unit (SMIU) under DIOS ID is dedicated to investigating allegations of Sexual misconduct involving UNRWA staff members in addition to beneficiaries, this includes Sexual Exploitation and Abuse (SEA) allegations as well as Sexual Harassment (SH) allegations, and any other sexual misconduct.

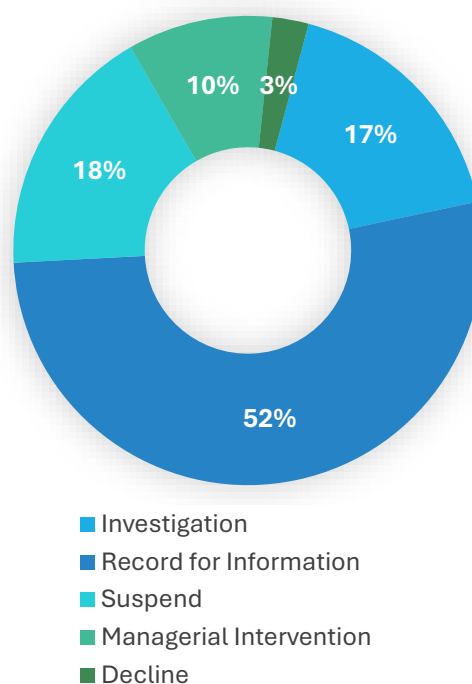
The SMIU is composed of two highly qualified investigators. In 2024, SMIU continued to collaborate with other departments throughout the year, especially their efforts in workshops participation, that were organized by other departments or units

(such as Ethics and Administrative Law Workshops) as well as informal discussions on the adoption of safeguarding measures for unsubstantiated SEA cases.

SMIU also continued to play a key role in providing advice and guidance.

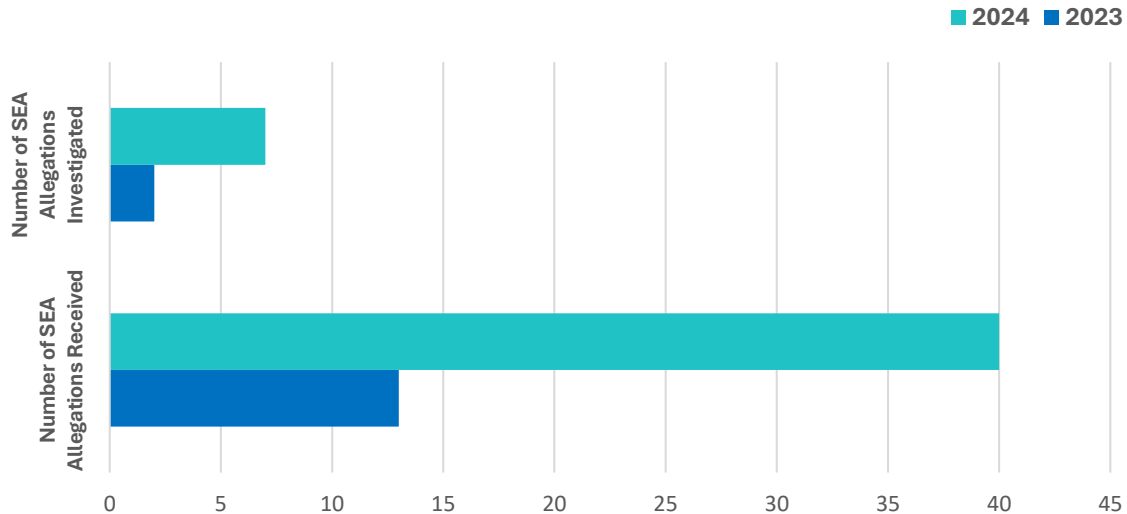
- Advising individuals regarding investigative and disciplinary procedures.
- Assisting field offices with sexual misconduct investigations.
- Guiding PSEA focal points on how to handle SEA allegations.

Figure 25. Intake decisions for SEA allegations



UNRWA Students in Gaza begin studying at the start of the new semester.
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Figure 26. SEA allegations and investigations (2023-2024)

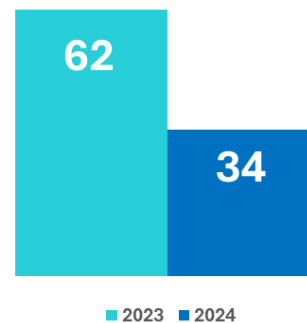


In 2024, the SMIU recorded a sharp increase in reported allegations, with **40** cases, compared to just 13 cases in 2023. This increase is largely due to the unit's stronger engagement with key stakeholders, such as Protection, the Ethics Office, Counselling Services, and Ombudsperson.

As for investigated cases, **seven** cases were predicated for investigation in 2024 as opposed to only two in 2023. This was due to the enhanced collaboration and a victim-centered approach has contributed to greater case substantiation and a higher number of investigations moving forward the previous year.

the previous year. This decline is largely due to the careful and thorough assessments conducted by the CIU, ensuring that only evidence-based cases advance to the investigation stage as well as the absence of the high volume of investigations that was triggered by the 7 October attacks back in 2023.

Figure 27. Number of investigations opened by DIOS



A. Key Activities

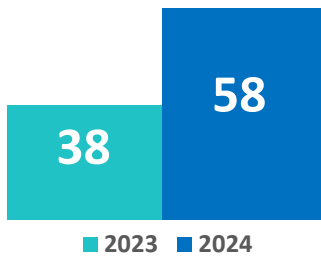
Investigations managed by the DIOS Investigations Division

Throughout 2024, DIOS ID saw a noticeable drop in the number of investigations initiated, compared to

In addition, DIOS ID managed to close serious and/or complex investigations (involving 80 misconduct allegations) in 2024, including cases that were initiated in previous years and carried over into 2024. This number represents a twofold increase

compared to the number of cases closed in 2023 and the 23 cases closed in 2022.

Figure 28. Number of investigations completed by DIOS



DIOS ID Support to Field Offices

In 2024, DIOS ID strengthened its investigations process by ensuring compliance with UNRWA guidelines and international best practices,

resulting in improved quality and standardization across Field Offices and a reduction in backlog cases. DIOS ID supported each of the five Field Offices, each with its own investigative team.

By the end of 2024, the **Field Offices investigation units were staffed with 15 fixed term General Services (Area) posts** complemented by few LDC and daily paid personnel. Despite this, investigations that remained decentralized under the Field Directors' authority presented risks, as local units in field offices had limited independence from senior management, which could lead to potential conflicts of interest when investigating allegations involving superiors. Additionally, this may raise concerns regarding the consistency, quality, and timeliness of the investigations.

Figure 29. A flow chart depicting the type of support provided by DIOS ID to Field Offices



Pilot to Centralize WBFO & SFO Investigations

DIOS ID continued with its efforts to improve the quality of WBFO and SFO investigations by centralizing the investigation function.

DIOS ID fulfilled its mandate to properly oversee and monitor the investigations functions of the Field

Investigation Offices and provide support and quality assurance for field-based investigations.

The pilot, which aims to centralize the WBFO and SFO investigation function, started in January 2024.

A new direction has been set in which the Senior Field Investigator will be directly reporting to the Senior Field Investigations Support Officer in DIOS HQ, while the second supervisor stays with the Director of WBFO

and the Director of SFO. Therefore, DIOS provided close and direct support for SFO and WBFO investigations staff including day-to-day supervision of the team and time management. The purpose of the pilot was to test the centralization process.

Strengthening Investigative Capacity

In 2024, DIOS ID performed two training assessments to assess the training needs of staff members in investigation units. Multiple gaps and development areas were identified following the assessments, and hence the training plan was then aligned with the development needs of the individual as well as the organizational objectives.

Challenges	DIOS ID Solution
Backlog Cases	Prioritization of aging cases and implementing a triage process for allegations.
Decentralization Issues	Centralized oversight for WBFO & SFO to streamline processes and reduce inefficiencies.
Investigation Timelines	Improved workload distribution and systematic monitoring to ensure more timely investigations.
Investigator Skill Gaps	Specialized training programs to enhance technical competency and case management skills.

DIOS continued to provide field investigators with the required knowledge for professional skills enhancement and to upgrade investigative practices. DIOS ID continued delivering bi-weekly sessions between August and September of 2024 on investigation methods such as Investigation governance in UNRWA and standards of evidence and

burden of proof, in addition to training sessions provided as needed on an array of investigations topics.

DIOS conducted an evaluation of its support to field investigation offices late 2024, which showed favorable results and an open feedback culture, indicating that the support provided by DIOS was highly valued amongst field investigators.

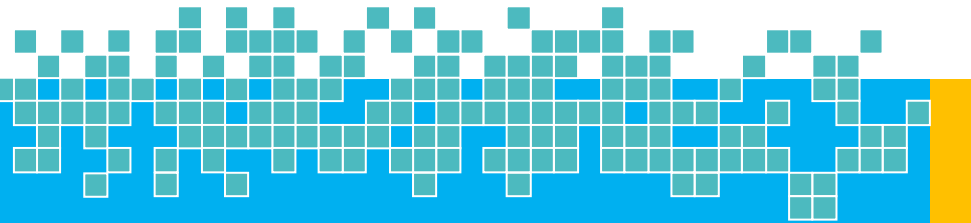
Challenges and solutions

In 2024, DIOS focused on resolving a backlog of cases (some dating back to 2021) and demonstrated a strong commitment to addressing overdue work. Looking ahead to 2025, with nearly all 2023 cases cleared, DIOS also plans to enhance performance indicators to improve efficiency and shorten processing times.

While there have been many achievements and improvements in multiple areas within the Division, several challenges remain persistent that require attention to ensure the continued success of DIOS ID’s operations.

Way Forward (2025 and beyond)

In 2025, DIOS ID will continue building the trust of stakeholders by enhancing its intake process through an **efficient triage strategy** that will prioritize backlog cases, as well as implementing a strategy that will target the reduction of the investigation backlog. Through focusing on cases with prima facie evidence, DIOS ID will be able to enhance the efficiency of



investigations and make sure that resources are best allocated.

A vital component of this strategy will be the employment of a **digital transformation** that will improve case tracking, elevate the efficiency and efficacy of investigation operations, in addition to heightening the technical competency of investigators, to ensure faster and higher-quality investigation work across all field offices.

Moreover, UNRWA will seek a no-cost extension for the EU grant, set to expire in 2026, with the possibility of extending operations into 2027.

Meanwhile, an **independent external assessment of the investigation function** in 2025 will provide valuable external perspective to further optimize the investigation process.



Immediate need for food, health and psychosocial support for Palestinians sheltering at UNRWA schools in Gaza
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Palestine refugee children at the UNRWA Jabalia Co-Educational School participate in the 2022 UNRWA Summer Fun Weeks. © 2022 UNRWA Photo by Mohammed Hinnawi